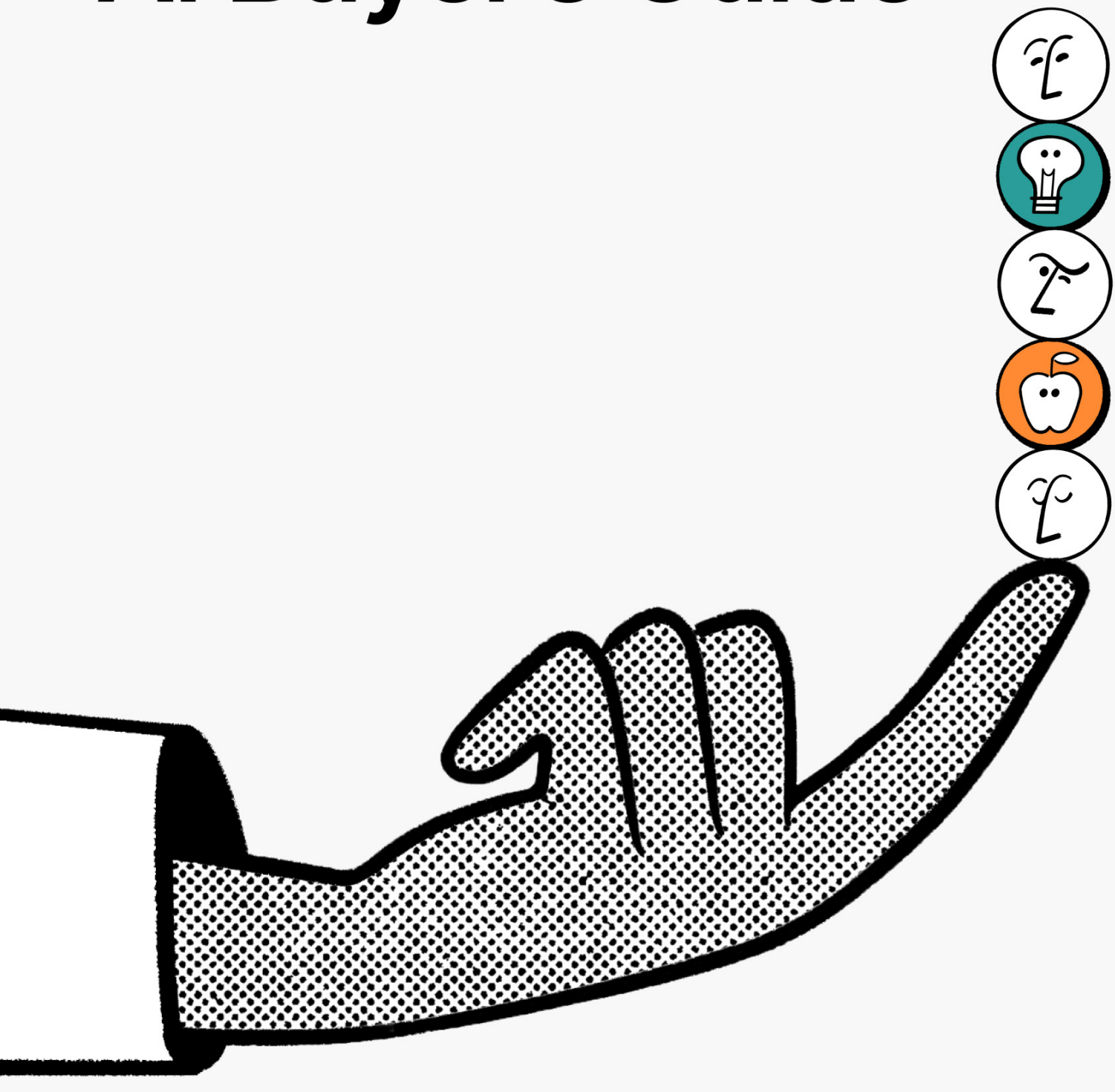
Notion

The Ultimate AI Buyer's Guide

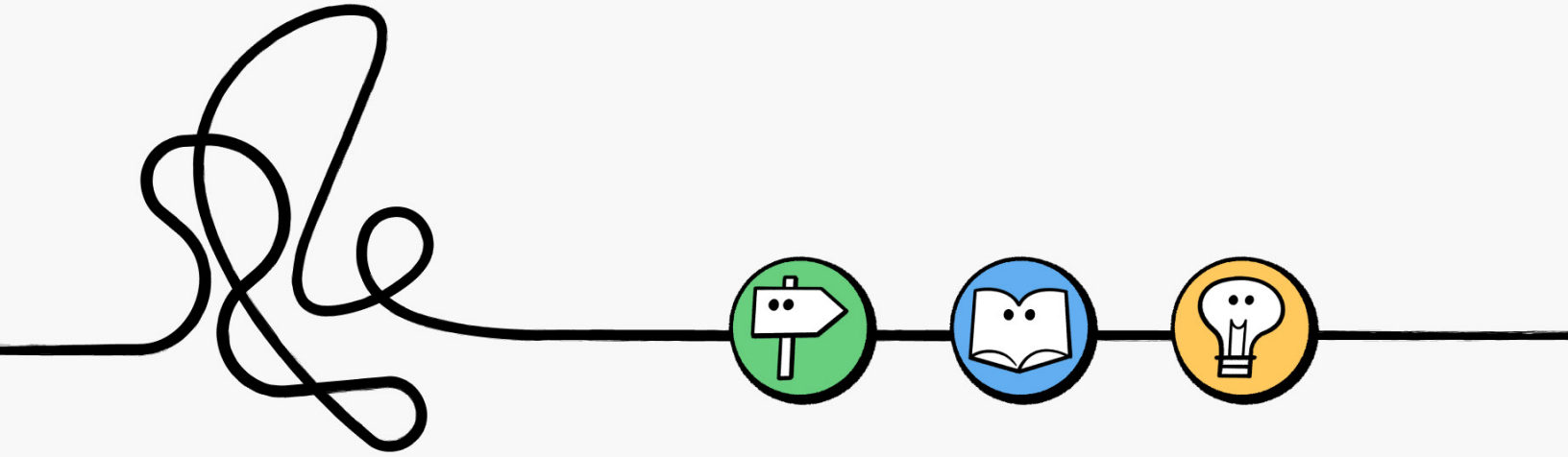


There’s a gap between AI excitement and AI execution

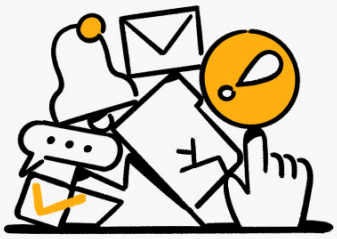
Every company is exploring AI these days. The enthusiasm is real—AI promises to handle busywork, answer questions instantly, and keep teams in sync. AI capabilities now rank among the top reasons decision-makers evaluate new software. Many companies have even set mandates to become more AI-native.

But most teams are approaching AI adoption in reverse: Adding powerful capabilities on top of already fragmented systems, hoping the technology alone will drive real value. The end result is a patchwork of AI tools that don’t integrate, can’t access information they need, and make knowledge sprawl even worse.

> “Most teams are approaching AI adoption in reverse.”



What's happening

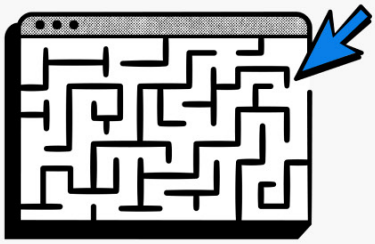


Companies are struggling. The question is no longer whether you *have* AI, it's whether you actually use it. We surveyed over 1,600 knowledge workers in the US to find out how they're thinking about implementing AI at work and where they're hitting roadblocks. We distilled their thoughts and created this guide for a big picture look at the landscape of AI tools for work.

In this guide, we'll show you:

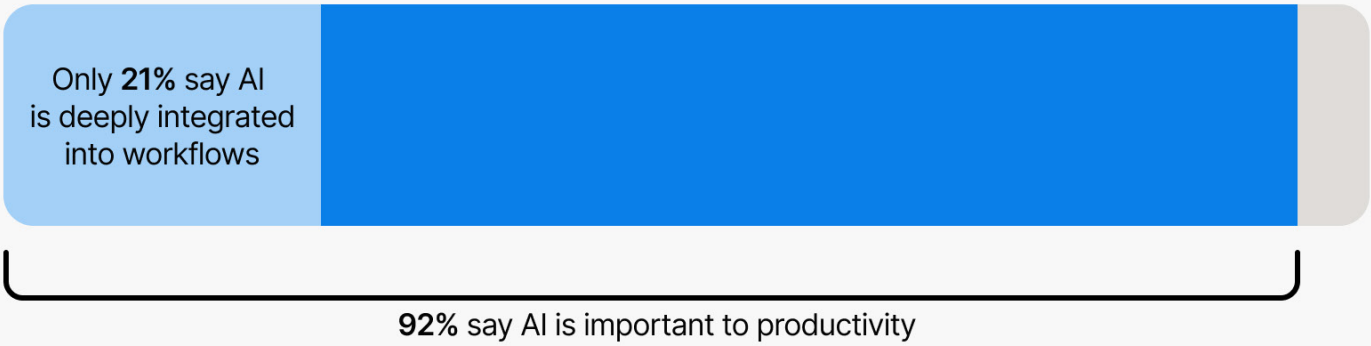
- **The critical jobs teams are "hiring" AI to do**—the specific problems AI should solve in day-to-day work
- **What "good" looks like for each job,** including different solution approaches and the trade-offs of specialized tools vs. integrated platforms
- **How to make a decision that *actually* works for your team,** not just what sounds impressive on paper or in a demo
- If you're evaluating AI as part of a broader platform decision—caring not just about capabilities but about adoption, integration, and whether your team will actually use it—**we'll help you ask the right questions**

AI is widely valued—but rarely built into daily work



Most teams agree AI can improve productivity. But far fewer have integrated it into the tools and workflows where work actually happens — a gap that becomes harder to ignore as teams move beyond early experiments.

71-point gap in AI value vs. AI adoption



Source: Qualtrics Productivity Study. Commissioned by Notion. Fielded July and October 2025. N = 1,455. US Only. How important is it that productivity software includes AI functionality?

Source: Numerious B2C2B Study. Commissioned by Notion. Fielded October 2025. N = 400. US Only. Where is your organization in terms of integrating AI into your productivity software tools?

The critical jobs that AI can solve at work



Not all AI use cases are created equal. Some address real challenges teams face every day, while others solve problems that don't meaningfully move work forward. To understand where AI can have the most impact, we asked teams about their biggest work challenges.

Top work challenges

MaxDiff Ranking

Too much time on repetitive tasks	6.9
Info scattered across multiple tools	5.9
Switching between too many tools	5.4

Other challenges

- Tools lacking flexibility
- Poor integration between tools
- Limited tool support/training
- Work happening in silos

Source: Numerious B2C2B Study. Commissioned by Notion. Fielded October 2025. N = 400. US Only. Which of the following is MOST important for a productivity software tool to solve? Which is LEAST important?

Five critical jobs for AI at work

The following sections break down the most important jobs teams are hiring AI to do today. Each one looks at the underlying challenge, what good looks like in practice, and the trade-offs between different approaches.

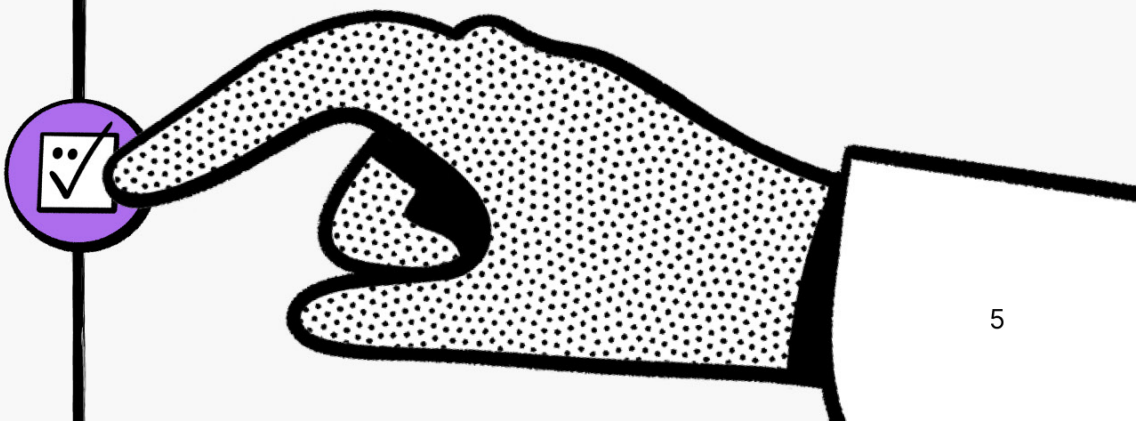
1 **Automating redundant workflows**
Reduce manual execution

2 **Finding information instantly**
Search across everything

3 **Scaling knowledge management**
Keep knowledge connected

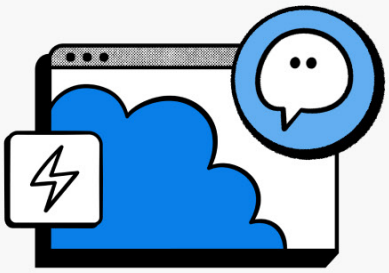
4 **Capturing and synthesizing meetings**
Turn conversations into action

5 **Creating comprehensive docs**
From scattered info to clarity



JOB #1

Automating redundant workflows



The challenge

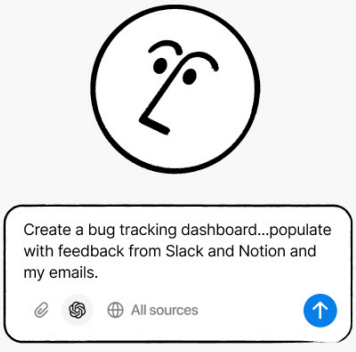
Teams spend hours every week on repetitive work that requires consistent execution but not deep thinking. Following up on incomplete tasks. Routing requests to the right people based on context. Answering commonly-asked questions from teammates. Each task might only take five minutes, but multiply that across every team member and every week, and you're looking at significant time that could be spent on strategic work.

The challenge is that these workflows aren't quite simple enough for basic automation—they require some intelligence and context to execute properly. You can't just set up a rigid rule that says "if X happens, do Y" because the right action depends on nuance: Who's available? What's the priority? What related work is already in progress?

> "It would free people up to focus their efforts on other tasks, and it would increase productivity both individually and on the group level."
>
> **—DIRECTOR AT TECHNOLOGY COMPANY (2,000-4,999 EMPLOYEES)**

What good looks like

AI agents that autonomously handle multi-step workflows with intelligence. You define the workflow once—what triggers it, what information it needs, what actions to take—and the AI agent executes it consistently without manual intervention.



How it works in practice

The agent can make contextual decisions based on your team's data: It knows who owns what, what's in progress, what's overdue. It can handle tasks like sending follow-ups when action items aren't completed, routing customer requests to the right team based on the issue type, or generating weekly summaries by pulling from your project databases and recent activity. The work gets done reliably, and your team gets their time back.

JOB #1

Not all automation is created equal



Traditional automation tools

Traditional automation tools like Zapier or Make connect apps together with if-this-then-that logic. They're powerful for moving data between systems and triggering actions based on events. You can build complex multi-step workflows that handle repetitive tasks.

The trade–offs

- Rule-based systems without intelligence
- You must anticipate every scenario
- Break or misfire when something doesn't fit the exact rule
- Significant setup time and ongoing maintenance as workflows evolve

Workflow builders inside individual tools

Workflow builders in existing platforms like Slack Workflow Builder or Jira automation let you automate tasks within that specific tool. They're easier to set up than cross-platform automation tools and work well for simple, contained workflows.

The trade–offs

- Limited to a single tool's ecosystem
- Struggle when workflows span multiple systems
- Often require manual work or cobbled-together automations
- Platform-specific automations don't communicate with each other

Embedded AI agents

Embedded AI agents like Custom Agents in Notion can handle more nuanced decision-making because they understand context from your connected data. They can execute multi-step workflows that require evaluating current state, making judgment calls, and taking appropriate action. Because the agent has access to your workspace and connected tools, it can work across systems without rigid programming.

The trade–offs

- Effectiveness depends on well-structured workflows
- Requires data to be organized in a way the agent can access and understand

JOB #2

Finding information instantly



The challenge

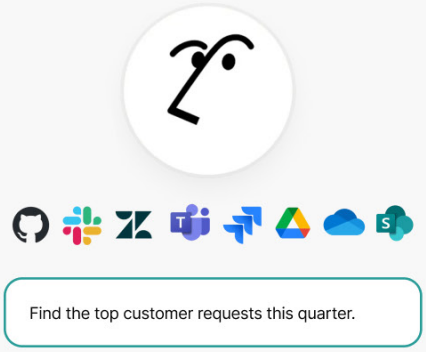
Conversations happen in Slack and email, files are stored in Google Drive and Figma, pull requests tracked in GitHub, customer data in Salesforce. Finding what you need often means hunting in a forest of apps or waiting hours for a teammate to reply. What should take seconds takes minutes—multiply that by every question and employee and day, and you start to see the real cost.

It's more than just an inconvenience. When information is scattered, people spend more time searching than doing. Teams waste hours every week digging through disconnected systems to find answers that should simply be immediately accessible.

> "It would save time searching for information and reduce the risk of using outdated or incorrect data."
>
> **—DIRECTOR AT TECHNOLOGY COMPANY (300-499 EMPLOYEES)**

What good looks like

A unified search that understands what you're asking. You can ask open-ended questions in natural language like "What's the latest on our upcoming brand campaign?" and the AI searches across all your connected tools—not just your docs but also your Slack messages, Jira tickets, GitHub activity.



How it works in practice

Results are **permission-aware** so you only see what you should have access to. The search also **understands context**: When you ask about "the customer issue from yesterday," it knows which customer and which issue based on your recent work. Answers come with source citations so you can verify and dig deeper.

JOB #2

AI search is only as good as its context

Standalone enterprise search tools

Standalone enterprise search tools like Glean are dedicated platforms designed specifically for finding information across your stack. These tools integrate with many applications through connectors and offer sophisticated search algorithms to surface relevant results across large organizations.

The trade–offs

- Search results appear in a separate interface from your work
- You must switch contexts to find information
- Then switch back again to apply it
- It requires adopting another tool
- It adds another subscription to manage

AI chat tools with limited context

AI chat interfaces with limited context like ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini are powerful language models that excel at answering questions and synthesizing information based on what you provide. They're excellent at reasoning and generating content, but they have no native access to your company's information.

The trade–offs

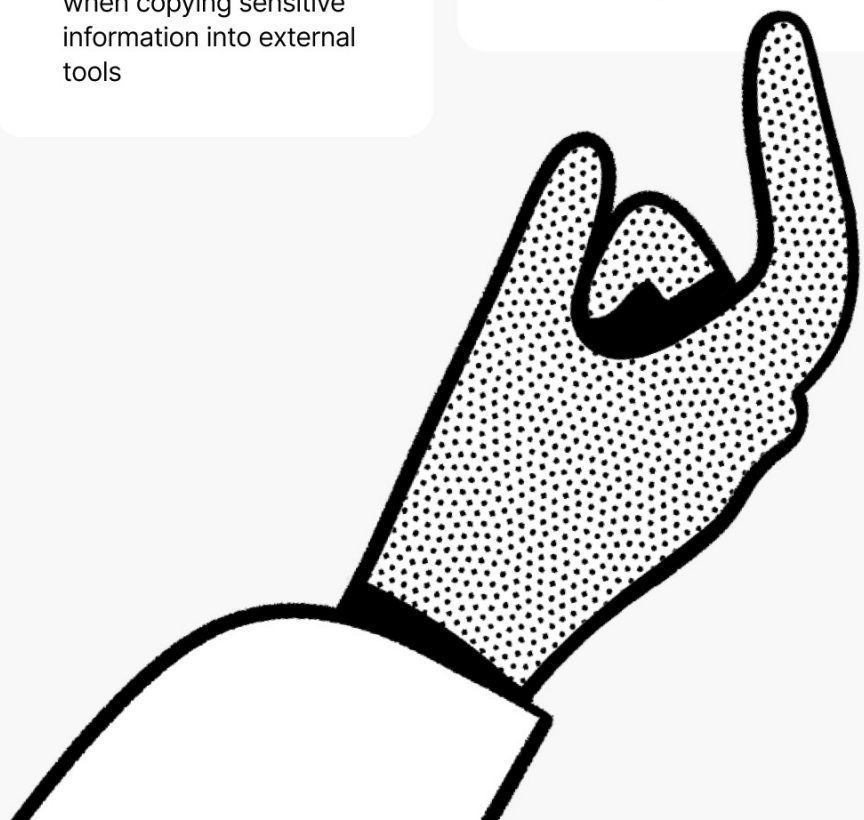
- You must manually paste context into the tool
- You can't search across your tools without gathering information yourself
- There are security concerns when copying sensitive information into external tools

Integrated workspace search

Integrated workspace search like Notion AI's Enterprise Search is built directly into where your team already works and stores information. It connects to external tools through AI Connectors for Slack, GitHub, Google Workspace, Jira, Microsoft Teams, and more. Search happens in the same interface where you're documenting, planning, and collaborating.

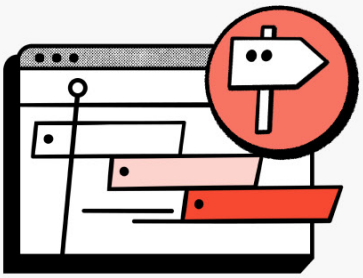
The trade–offs

- Requires your team to use the workspace platform
- Effectiveness depends on how much knowledge lives in the workspace
- Also depends on how much information is connected to that workspace



JOB #3

Scaling knowledge management



The challenge

Your knowledge systems don't scale and are hard to access.

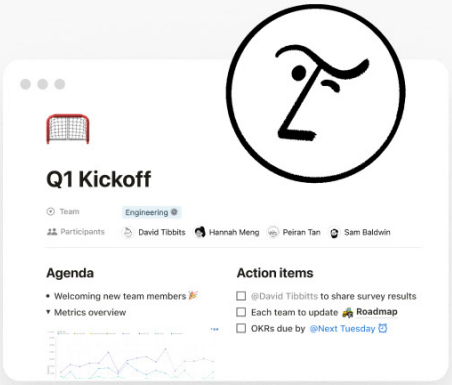
When you're small, everyone knows where everything is and can ask each other questions. As you grow, that informal, ad hoc system breaks down—the person who knows the answer might be in a different timezone, overwhelmed with their own work, or no longer at the company. You build a wiki to document everything, but finding the right information means knowing it exists and where to look—new team members are constantly asking "Where do I find...?"

This problem only gets worse with scale. What worked for a team of 20 completely falls apart at 200. Documentation sprawls, duplicates accumulate, and no one is quite sure what's current versus what's outdated. The institutional knowledge that makes teams effective becomes increasingly difficult to access.

> "Our company is expanding rapidly and we need tools that can keep up with that growth."
>
> **—CHIEF X OFFICER (CXO) AT TECHNOLOGY COMPANY (300-499 EMPLOYEES)**

What good looks like

Connected, verifiable, AI-accessible knowledge. All your team's knowledge lives in a system that's easy to find and well-organized. AI can search across this knowledge to answer questions, even for people who don't know what documentation exists.

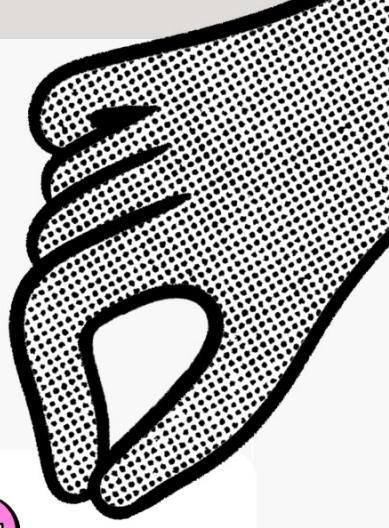


How it works in practice

Information is **trustworthy** because there are clear verification processes and you can see when pages were last updated. Knowledge can be **connected to the projects, tasks, and decisions** to make it more actionable. As your organization grows, the system **scales without requiring exponentially more effort to maintain**.

JOB #3

Knowledge systems need to scale with you



Traditional wikis with AI layered on top

Traditional wikis like Confluence or SharePoint allow teams to use an existing documentation system and add AI capabilities through plugins or built-in features. This preserves prior investments in documentation and structure, and teams don't need to adopt an entirely new tool.

The trade–offs

- The AI layer is disconnected from where work actually happens (projects, tasks, meetings)
- Search and AI only function within the wiki tool
- They don't extend to conversations and collaboration spaces
- This leaves teams with limited AI capabilities
- The features don't meaningfully support function or scale

AI-first knowledge tools

AI-first knowledge tools like Glean or Guru are designed specifically around AI-powered knowledge discovery. They offer strong search and question-answering capabilities and often include features for verification and content freshness.

The trade–offs

- It's another tool to adopt and manage
- Requires active maintenance to keep the knowledge base current
- Because it's disconnected from daily work

All-in-one platforms with embedded AI

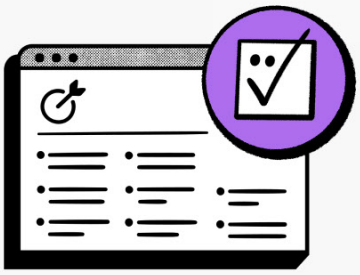
All-in-one platforms with embedded AI, like Notion with Notion AI, integrate knowledge management directly into where teams already plan, collaborate, and track work. AI has native access to documentation, projects, tasks, and notes, allowing information to stay connected and contextual as teams grow.

The trade–offs

- If you don't already use Notion, it requires migrating from existing systems
- Effectiveness depends on moving your workflows into the platform

JOB #4

Capturing and synthesizing meetings



The challenge

Even with the most dedicated note-taker, it's easy to lose sight of the decisions, ideas, and insights that come from meetings as soon as they end.

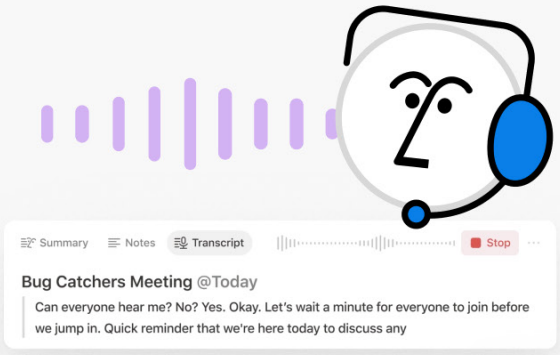
Meeting attendees are stuck splitting their attention between discussion and knowledge capture—you can't fully participate if you're trying to write everything down. Action items slip through the cracks because someone forgets to document them. Important context that other teams need down the line gets lost because notes are incomplete bullet points (if captured at all).

The cost of this lost information compounds over time. Teams revisit the same discussions because no one remembers what was decided. New hires struggle to understand why certain decisions were made. Critical context that would have prevented mistakes simply disappears.

> "We would have better alignment on priorities, and increased visibility into the progress of work. It would help to identify potential blockers and help us increase speed to market."
>
> **—DIRECTOR AT RETAIL COMPANY (5,000+ EMPLOYEES)**

What good looks like

Automatic transcription that creates a shared memory. AI summarizes the conversation, pulling out decisions made, action items assigned, and key discussion points.



How it works in practice

Summaries are **formatted consistently** so team members know where to look for specific information. Meeting notes are **stored where they connect to relevant projects**, making it easy to find that "thing we discussed three weeks ago." The system is **searchable so you can quickly surface past discussions** when they become relevant.

JOB #5

Not all meeting AI captures the full story

Meeting-specific transcription tools

Meeting-specific transcription tools like Otter.ai are purpose-built for meeting transcription and summaries. They offer strong audio processing and speaker identification, and often integrate with your calendar to automatically join meetings.

The trade–offs

- Notes live in a separate tool from projects and documentation
- Team members must check another platform to find meeting outcomes
- It's another subscription to manage

Built-in AI features in video conferencing tools

Video conferencing built-in features like Zoom AI Companion offer native integration with your video tool, which means no extra bot joining meetings. Summaries and recordings live where the meeting happened.

The trade–offs

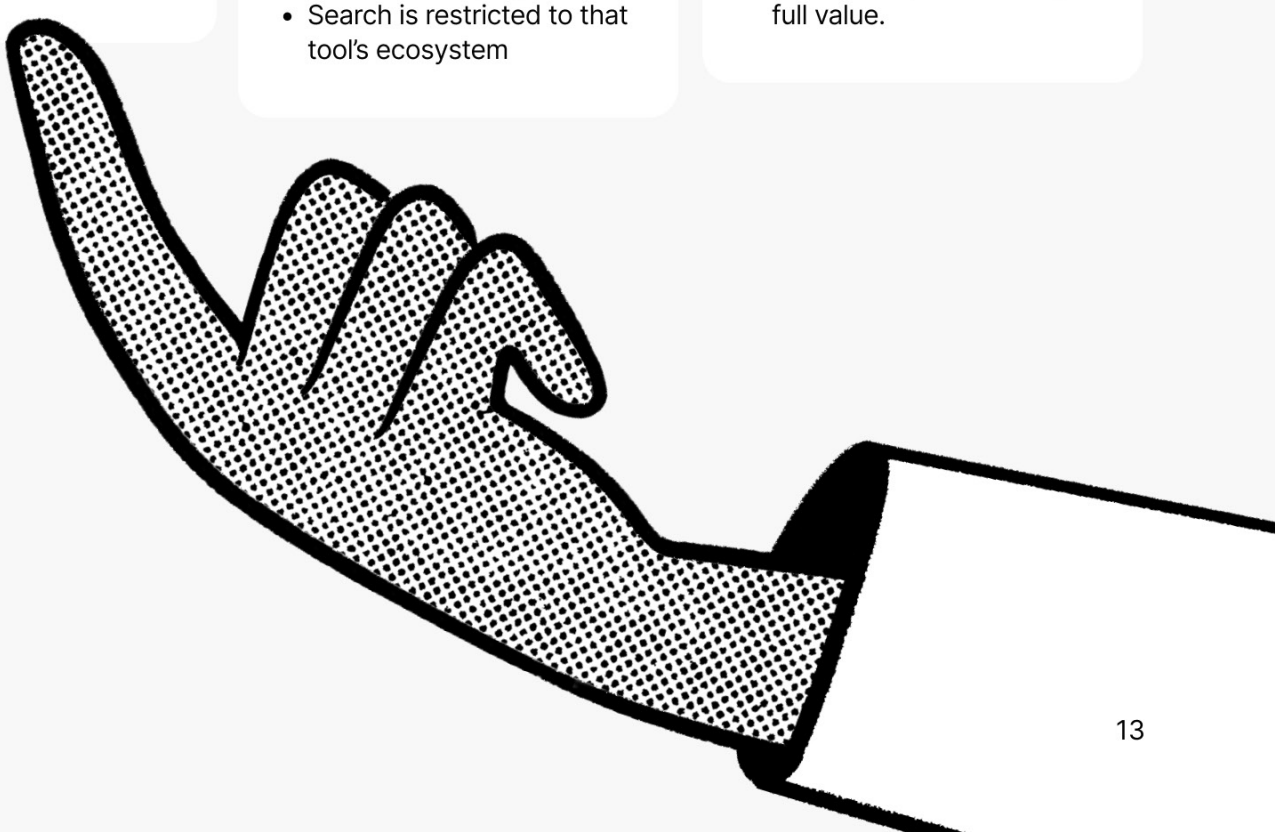
- Features are limited to meetings held in that specific platform
- They don't cover phone calls or in-person discussions
- Notes are siloed within the video tool rather than connected to project work
- Search is restricted to that tool's ecosystem

AI note-taking embedded in your workspace

AI note-taking embedded in your workspace like Notion's AI Meeting Notes automatically generates meeting notes and stores them where work is already happening. Notes connect to relevant projects, tasks, and teamspaces so context is preserved. It can be used across in-person and digital meetings, and across platforms. Everything is searchable with Notion AI that has access to both meetings and related project information.

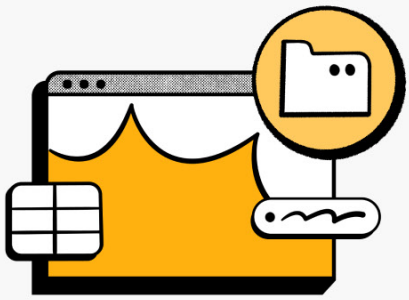
The trade–offs

- You need to be using that workspace platform to get full value.



JOB #5

Creating comprehensive docs



The challenge

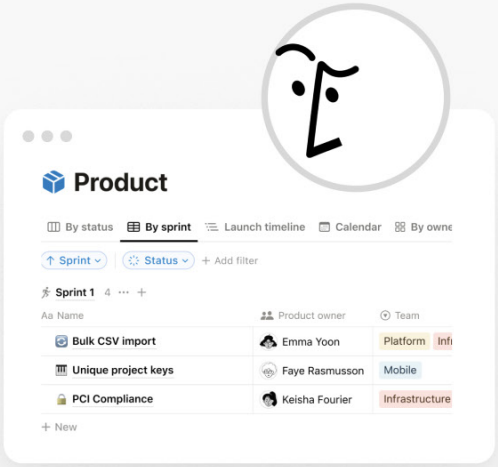
Researching and pulling information together in a document takes a ton of time and effort.

You get a request for an update on your team's project or that all-too-familiar question: "Do we have this documented somewhere?" The information you need exists—spread across Slack messages, Jira tickets, Google Docs, meeting notes, and the web. Pulling everything together and polishing it into a shareable document will eat up the better part of a day. It's time that could have been spent on strategic work, but instead it's consumed by manually gathering information and synthesizing knowledge.

> "We wouldn't have to switch between apps or copy information manually, and it would be easier to stay organized and keep everyone on the same page."
>
> **—DIRECTOR AT TECHNOLOGY COMPANY (50-99 EMPLOYEES)**

What good looks like

AI that gathers and synthesizes scattered information and formats it into a well-organized doc. You describe what you need in a simple prompt: "Create a project update for our mobile app redesign including progress, blockers, and next steps."



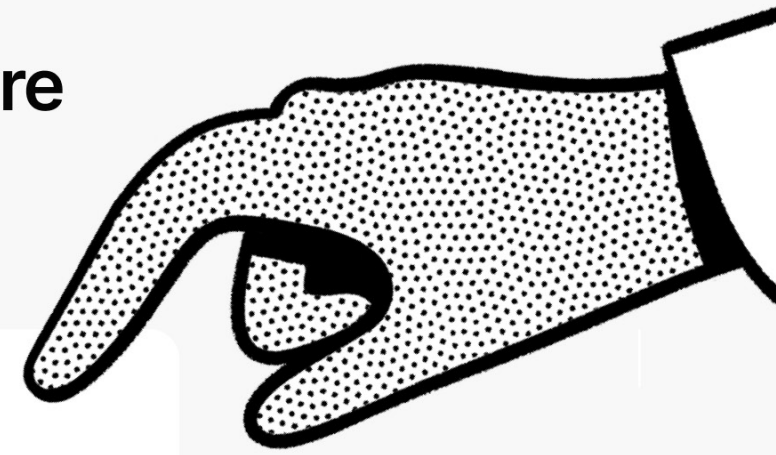
How it works in practice

The AI searches across your workspace, connected tools, and even the web if needed to find relevant information. It analyzes all sources and drafts a comprehensive document that's organized and ready to share. Your doc includes citations so readers can verify sources and dig deeper on specific points.

AI then automates this entire process based on triggers or schedules so docs and reports are created without you needing to prompt—or even remember that you need it in the first place.

JOB #5

Great docs require more than generation



Chat-based AI for document creation

General-purpose AI assistants like ChatGPT, Claude, or Gemini are powerful language models that excel at writing, reasoning, and synthesizing information. They can handle complex prompts and create sophisticated content.

The trade–offs

- They don't have access to your company's information unless you provide it manually
- You must gather all context yourself before asking for help
- Documents created in chat need to be copied to other tools

Format-specific AI writing tools

AI writing tools focused on specific formats like Jasper for marketing or GitHub Copilot for code are optimized for particular content types with relevant templates and features. They often have style controls and brand voice settings.

The trade–offs

- They are disconnected from your broader information ecosystem
- They often focus on creating content from scratch rather than synthesizing existing information
- They have limited ability to pull from multiple sources across your organization

Embedded AI for research and synthesis

Research-capable embedded AI like Notion AI's Research Mode can access multiple sources including your workspace, connected tools, and the web. It's designed to synthesize information from scattered sources into comprehensive docs. Notion's Custom Agents can automate report generation based on triggers or schedules so reports land in your inbox without having to ask.

The trade–offs

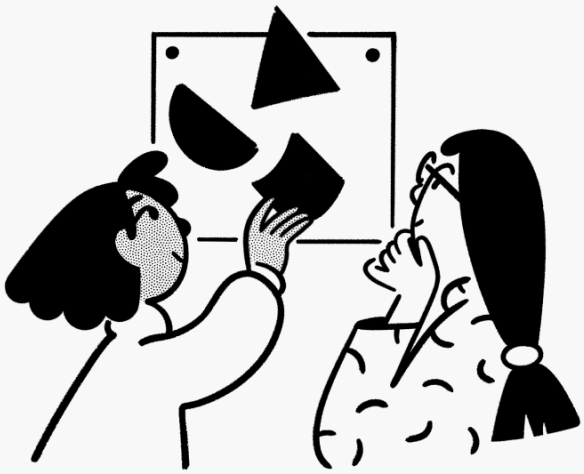
- Effectiveness depends on how much relevant information the AI tool can access

Making your decision

Before evaluating any tools, **start with a clear hypothesis.** Determine what capabilities matter most—there's no universal "best" AI solution, only the best solution for your specific challenges. Maybe your engineering team can't find documentation, or your product team is spending too long compiling project updates and writing PRDs.

Gut check yourself:

- [ ] **Does AI live where my team already works, or is it another tool to remember?**
- [ ] **Can it access our knowledge without manual setup and context-gathering?**
- [ ] **Will answers be explainable and trustworthy, with clear sources?**
- [ ] **Does this reduce our tool count or add to it?**



How to evaluate AI tools that will actually work

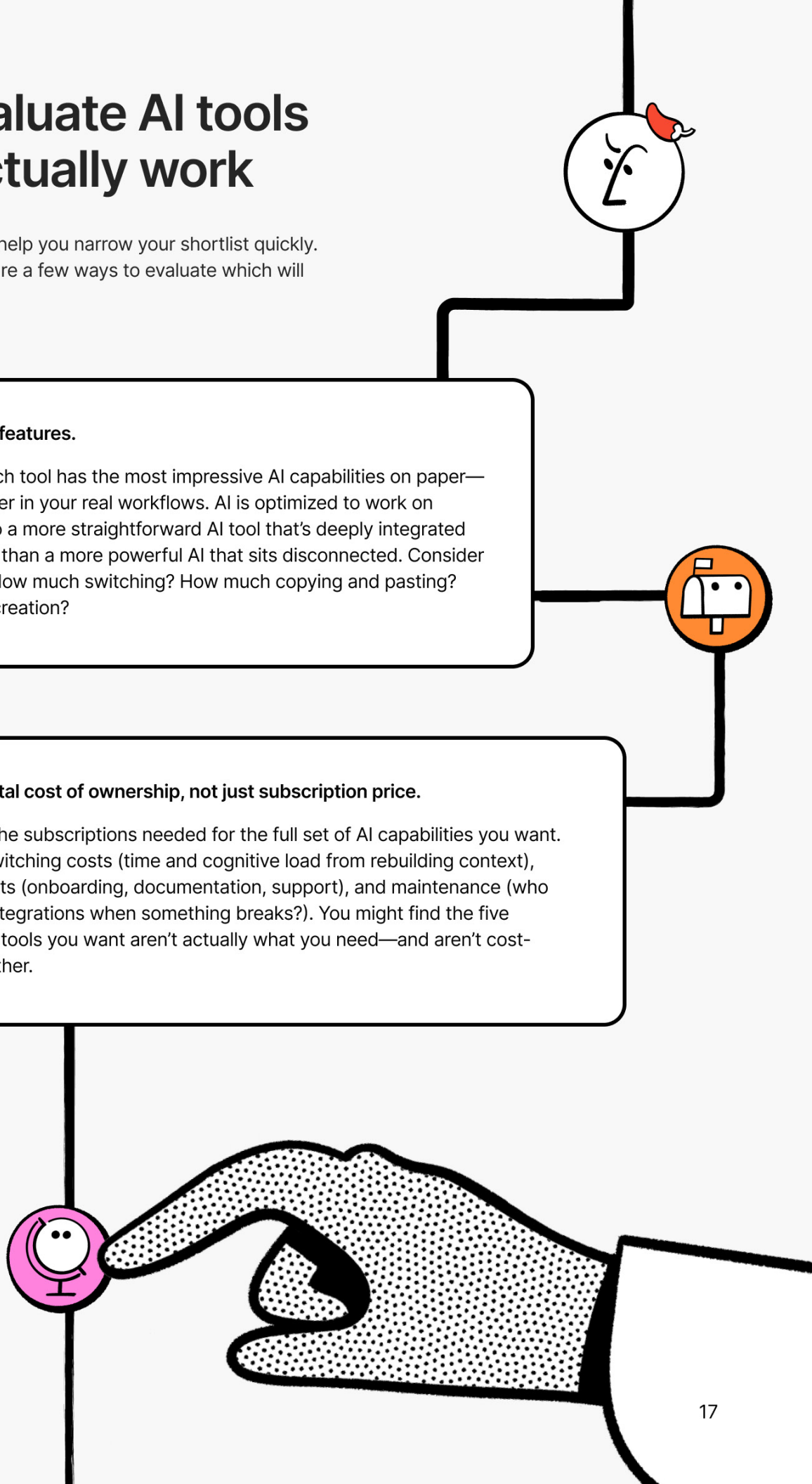
Questions like these should help you narrow your shortlist quickly. For options that pass, here are a few ways to evaluate which will actually work for your team.

Think in systems, not features.

The question isn't which tool has the most impressive AI capabilities on paper—it's how they fit together in your real workflows. AI is optimized to work on centralized context, so a more straightforward AI tool that's deeply integrated will deliver more value than a more powerful AI that sits disconnected. Consider the total experience: How much switching? How much copying and pasting? How much context recreation?

Evaluate total cost of ownership, not just subscription price.

Add up all the subscriptions needed for the full set of AI capabilities you want. Factor in switching costs (time and cognitive load from rebuilding context), training costs (onboarding, documentation, support), and maintenance (who manages integrations when something breaks?). You might find the five specialized tools you want aren't actually what you need—and aren't cost-effective either.



Plan for organizational change, not just technical implementation.

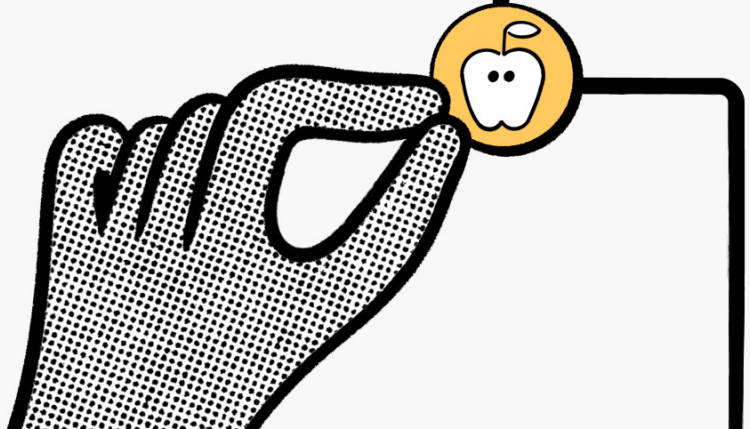
AI adoption requires change management. Consider your champions: Do they have bandwidth to manage multiple tool rollouts, or do they need simplicity? Think about your team's current tool fatigue and whether there's appetite for consolidation versus adding more specialized solutions.

Look for proof of adoption, not just case studies.

Case studies show what's possible, but may not be what typical teams experience. Ask for actual adoption metrics: "What percentage of your customers' employees are monthly active AI users?" Request references similar to your organization and find out how long it took them to reach strong adoption.

Ask technical questions that matter.

Where does the AI tool live? If you already use specific tools, how does that AI tool access your information? How is your data protected?



The question that matters most

Ultimately, the question that matters most is this: **“Will our team actually use this AI consistently to do better work, or will it become another subscription we pay for but rarely use?”** If you can’t answer that confidently, you need more piloting, clearer success criteria, or a different solution approach.

Contact sales

Learn how Notion can work for your team with a personalized consultation

Take a Product Tour

See Notion AI in-action in this 2-min interactive demo

